

KAIRAVI DESAI BILGI, *45*
Company Secretary based in Ahmedabad
INVESTS IN: ***Stocks, MFs, ETFs***

"Access to information and understanding is much easier now"

She was 18 when she began investing Rs 3,000 gathered from internships in the 1990s in the stock market through a portfolio management service (PMS). "I had learnt the basics of the market from my grandfather," she recalls.

The mother of two has come a long way since, taking active calls with her PMS consultant to invest in ETFs or exchange-traded funds, gold, silver and equity trading. While 50 per cent of her portfolio consists of mutual funds, her favourites are IPOs (initial public offering). "I study the offer closely and have rarely been disappointed. I also book my profits early," she says. A company secretary in a women's start-up, she tracks companies and sectors through news in mainstream and social media, but keeps away from finfluencers.

From a third generation of educated women in the family, financial autonomy, especially over her income, came naturally to Kairavi, but it is only in the past two years that she has actively started participating in market activities. "Access to information and understanding is much easier now," she says. She sees a lot of her younger female colleagues using online apps to invest.

"My targets aren't lofty—usually a luxury jewellery piece or a vacation with family or on my own. But I do see the potential of this becoming sustainable with more time and focus," she says.

tion rate (LFPR) for those aged 15 and above touched 35.3 per cent in December 2025, a significant rise from the 23.3 per cent in 2017-18. Women thus now have more disposable income in their hands. The numbers in the above surveys are of dual-income households where finances are co-managed, as well as of single, urban women who now manage personal wealth independently, a segment that was almost entirely missing in India 15 years ago.

The Making of a Revolution

Women's relationship with money in India is undergoing a decisive transformation. Greater access to higher education and improved financial awareness have enabled women to exercise greater agency over their income. Legal reforms granting daughters equal rights in family property and inheritance have reinforced this shift, removing structural barriers that historically limited women's financial independence. As a result, young women today increasingly see earning, managing and investing money not as a deviation from social norms but as a natural extension of their autonomy. Rather than restricting themselves to traditionally "safe" instruments like gold or fixed deposits, many are exploring growth-oriented investments such as mutual funds and equities.

Institutional efforts have played a pivotal role in accelerating this change. Organisations such as the Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI) and the NSE have expanded financial literacy initiatives focused specifically on women. AMFI's 'Mutual Funds Sahi Hai' campaign helped normalise mutual fund investing among retail participants, while the NSE conducted 3,016 investor awareness programmes exclusively for women in the past year, reaching nearly 150,000 participants. Brokerage firm Zerodha further strengthened the ecosystem with 'Her Interest', a women-focused financial education and peer-support community.

Social media played its part too. A 2025 study by Kantar and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), covering 90,000 households, found that 93 per cent of Indian investors consider financial influencers (finfluencers) moderately to highly credible. Such voices have helped demystify markets and encouraged first-time participation.